# LONG AGO AND FAR AWAY



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**Gondhla Castle, Lahaul**

**Watercolour and tempera on paper**

**8.5x5.5 cm**

Bireswar Sen, 1920

One of the northernmost territories in India and literally 'the southern lands' according to its Tibetan name, Lo-yul—or Lahaul—has always been an enigmatic place. Cut off from the rest of the world as the snows closed the surrounding passes each winter, the valley developed a unique culture related to but equidistant from the neighbouring kingdoms of Kulu and Tibet. Now that the newly-built Atal tunnel has pierced its ancient idyll of winter isolation, one of the first sights tourists will encounter on the road to Keylong (see **Paradise Found** on page 296) is the striking 'castle' of Gondhla. This imposing tower, built in the 18th century, once housed the 'Thakurs' of Gondhla, local potentates who owed political allegiance to Kulu and spiritual deference to Lhasa. It's abandoned today, though the Thakurs' descendants live in a cosy home nearby. But a hundred and one years ago, the noted painter Bireswar Sen, sometime disciple of both Nandlal Bose and Nicholas Roerich, captured the scene on a starry night before they turned out the lights in the castle.